

Megatherium

Also called the giant sloth, *Megatherium* was a close cousin of modern tree sloths, but this prehistoric beast was as big as an elephant and lived on the ground. Fossilized dung shows it was a herbivore that ate dozens of different kinds of plant. It normally walked on all fours but could also rear up on its hindlimbs to reach high branches, which it pulled down with its claws. *Megatherium* vanished soon after humans first reached the Americas, perhaps hunted to extinction.



▲ MOST *Megatherium* fossils have been found in the pampas, a grassy area in South America. This bone was among a find of 12 animals revealed when a drought caused a river in Argentina to dry up.

